

# Care about and care for

## Teaching guide

Say what matters to you and who you look after.

## Understand the distinction

Care about commonly means consider important: I care about the environment. Care for can mean look after: She cares for her father. Take care of also means look after or deal with.

Care for can mean like or want in some contexts: I do not care for this music; Would you care for some tea? These uses are often more formal. I do not care can sound dismissive, so choose a clearer phrase when you simply have no preference.

## Compare the patterns

### IMPORTANCE

I care about the result.

The result matters to me.

### LOOK AFTER

I care for my grandmother.

I help look after her.

### NO PREFERENCE

Either time works for me.

A considerate alternative to I do not care.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

## Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the phrase that expresses concern for an issue: We care \_\_\_\_ clean water.

- A. about
- B. of
- C. to

2. He cares for his elderly neighbor by cooking meals and helping with daily tasks. What does cares for mean here?

- A. Look after.
- B. Ask the neighbor for advice.
- C. Have no preference about.

3. Choose an alternative to I do not care when either restaurant is fine.

- A. Either restaurant is fine with me.
- B. Neither restaurant is acceptable.
- C. I strongly prefer the first restaurant.

## Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Punctuality matters to you, but you accept either cafe. Which pair communicates both points?

- A. I care about arriving on time. Neither cafe is acceptable.
- B. I care about arriving on time. Either cafe works for me.
- C. I do not care about arriving on time. Either cafe works for me.

### Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

### Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

## Answers and explanation

### 1. A. about

This expresses importance or concern.

B: Care about introduces a concern or issue; care of does not fit this verb phrase.

C: Care to normally takes a verb, as in care to join, not the noun phrase clean water.

### 2. A. Look after.

The context describes providing care.

B: The phrase describes giving care, not seeking advice.

C: Cares for his elderly neighbor here means looks after the neighbor.

### 3. A. Either restaurant is fine with me.

This states a preference without sounding dismissive.

B: This rejects both restaurants; the intended meaning accepts either.

C: This expresses a preference, whereas the intended meaning is no preference.

### 4. B. I care about arriving on time. Either cafe works for me.

Care about expresses the concern; either cafe accepts both options.

A: Neither rejects both cafes, contrary to the stated preference.

C: This denies the stated importance of punctuality.

### Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: [englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-33.html](https://englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-33.html)

# A practical teaching sequence

## 1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

## 2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

## 3. Apply (5 minutes)

Punctuality matters to you, but you accept either cafe. Which pair communicates both points?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

## 4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

### Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

### Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.